



The generosity ecosystem framework (GEF): a comprehensive approach to giving

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Abstract

Generosity plays a crucial role in addressing economic and social inequalities worldwide. Generosity research has garnered attention from various disciplines; however, to date, it has largely taken a piecemeal approach, focusing on either the generous individual or the recipient. Aiming to fill this gap, we conducted an extensive literature review on generosity and developed the proposed Generosity Ecosystem Framework (GEF). GEF analyzes the interactions and influences of various actors and their outcomes at different ecosystem levels (micro, meso, and macro). The interchange between the micro, meso, and macro levels creates a dynamic ecosystem where generosity is cultivated. Individual actions inspire community engagement, and vice versa, whereas organizational collaborations amplify these efforts within a supportive societal framework. Understanding these interrelations is vital for developing effective strategies to promote generosity at all ecosystem levels. GEF contributes to the nonprofit marketing, service, and business literature by reducing conceptual ambiguity, providing a theoretical foundation for future research, and enabling actionable decisions.

Keywords Generosity · Altruism · Philanthropy · Giving · Donation · Ecosystem · Well-being

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1 Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic, geopolitical conflicts, energy wars, natural disasters, rising economic inequality, and poverty have prompted unprecedented humanitarian crises, shaking global economic systems and human lives. These challenges have prompted individuals, businesses, nonprofit organizations, and governments to contribute their resources (e.g., money, time, and skills) to reduce human suffering and elevate their experiences (Fisk et al., 2020; Tsiotsou et al., 2024). Generosity has become pivotal in alleviating or diminishing economic and social inequalities, primarily by supporting educational and health systems. According to Giving USA (2024), individual donations, corporate donations, bequests, and foundation giving reached \$557.16 billion in 2023, an increase of 1.9% from 2022.

Moreover, formal and informal volunteers engage in extraordinary efforts to assist those in need (Lorente et al., 2024). These volunteers reach out to those disproportionately affected by the pandemic, natural disasters, and the economic crisis, bringing together support and activism for racial injustice and systemic inequity, mobilizing civic participation, and driving giving and action for causes and communities worldwide (Giving USA, 2024). For example, GivingTuesday is a global movement that encourages generosity and supports several non-profit organizations. In 2023, the total amount donated globally surpassed 1.5 trillion dollars with individual giving reaching \$512 billion, businesses amounted \$860 billion, and foundations \$122 billion (Giving Tuesday, 2024).

Not surprisingly, research on generosity is flourishing, attracting attention from various disciplines such as sociology, social psychology, political science, marketing, economics, anthropology, and evolutionary psychology (Zhang et al., 2021). Scholars have demonstrated enormous variance in the definition, conceptualization, theoretical perspectives, and research focus of generosity. Generosity has been conceptualized as giving to others wholeheartedly (Glanville et al., 2016). It constitutes a unique variant of prosocial behavior reflecting voluntary actions oriented toward the welfare of others without expecting anything in return (Collett & Morrissey, 2007). Thus, defining and quantifying generosity adds a layer of complexity to its study. Generosity can take many forms (e.g., resource sharing, altruistic acts, and even policies aimed at enhancing employee well-being); consequently, these diverse definitions may result in uneven operationalization across research.

The literature has linked generosity to several positive outcomes for recipients (e.g., a higher sense of safety and protection against challenging situations; Gschwind, 2021) and givers (e.g., improved well-being, healthier lives, and lower mortality rates; Nelson & Fritzell, 2014). Whereas generosity is likely associated with positive outcomes, the challenge of proving causality limits our capacity to make unequivocal assumptions. Various studies on generosity in business have adopted a cross-sectional design, collecting data at a single moment. However, cross-sectional designs are ineffective for establishing causal links because they do not follow changes over time. For example, a study linking corporate generosity and employee well-being used cross-sectional data (e.g., Shehzad & Siddiqui, 2021); however, it could not rule out a reverse relationship. Thus, it could not determine whether employees' well-being improves generosity or whether generosity leads to increased well-being. The

question of reverse causality is critical to generosity research. Generosity may be the result of beneficial effects, such as increased organizational performance or employee happiness, rather than the source of these outcomes. Also, social desirability bias or common method variance could affect self-reported measures of generosity or organizational results. This could change the observed link between generosity and business success. Another recognized limitation in generosity research is contextual variability. The influence of generosity varies between organizational and cultural contexts, thus limiting the generalizability of study findings. (e.g., Cowell et al., 2017).

The study of generosity encompasses diverse scholarly approaches and perspectives. For instance, one stream of research focuses on questions such as who provides useful information to fundraising experts and policymakers (Srnrka et al., 2003). Nevertheless, others have focused on the generosity virtue of the individual, mainly examining why people are being generous (MacKenzie et al., 2019; Romano et al., 2021; Tsiotsou, 2004) or what are the consequences of generosity for businesses (Wu et al., 2021). Common in generosity research are the adoption of economic theories, nonprofit marketing perspectives, or sociological and social-psychological approaches (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007; Sharp & Randhawa, 2014; Tsiotsou, 2006).

Despite the growing interest in generosity, academic research has yet to apply a holistic approach. Most extant research has taken a piecemeal approach by focusing either on the givers' side (individuals or organizations; MacKenzie et al., 2019; Romano et al., 2021; Tsiotsou, 2004) or the recipients' side (individuals or nonprofit organizations; Collett & Morrissey, 2007; Nelson & Fritzell, 2014). A thorough understanding of this fragmented, multidisciplinary area of research is needed to disentangle previous piecemeal approaches and enrich scholarly understanding of the concept and its role in improving individual and societal well-being (Collett & Morrissey, 2007; Fisk et al., 2020). Moreover, most studies have focused on dyadic interactions (Miller, 2018; Rapert et al., 2021), disregarding triadic and networked relationships and the societal implications of generosity. Thus, a systemic approach is needed so that academics and practitioners across disciplines understand the full spectrum of generosity, its dynamics, and its complexities.

Given the apparent gaps in the literature and the expanding research interest in generosity, this study seeks to rectify these voids by proposing the Generosity Ecosystem Framework (GEF). GEF encompasses all potential actors, their interactions and influences, and levels of analysis. Therefore, this paper's overview of the extant knowledge base expands the theoretical foundation of generosity from an ecosystem perspective. Consequently, the study aims to (a) examine and critically assess existing knowledge on generosity, (b) synthesize the results into an integrative and multidisciplinary framework, and (c) identify knowledge gaps to suggest future research directives.

To this end, this paper employed a fine-grained analysis of the generosity literature on philanthropy, nonprofit marketing, sociology, social psychology, and economics, resulting in the proposed integrated GEF. GEF complements current knowledge by (a) proposing an ecosystem approach and providing a holistic understanding of generosity and (b) critically analyzing the interactions and influences at each level of the ecosystem (the macro, meso, and micro levels) to explore the dilemmas associated with generosity. To better illustrate the actors and influences at each ecosystem level,

we employed the actors-antecedents-decisions-outcomes (AADO) organizing framework (Tsiotsou & Boukis, 2022). The AADO framework is used here to identify the main stakeholders (actors) and clarify their interactions, decisions, and outcomes.

Overall, GEF contributes to marketing, nonprofit services, and business literature and practices in several meaningful ways. First, GEF helps reduce misunderstandings and conceptual ambiguity in generosity research and management by identifying all levels of analysis and the actors and stakeholders of generosity. Second, the proposed framework provides a theoretical foundation for academics from various disciplines to identify and elaborate on less-developed research areas in the future. Third, GEF makes generosity actionable and enables policymakers, nonprofits, and businesses in their decisions and practices.

The proposed framework seeks to meet some of the noted challenges in studying generosity. A more thorough theoretical framework can account for a broader variety of elements influencing generosity, such as personal and environmental factors. A paradigm that incorporates multiple perspectives can more effectively illustrate the complexities of generosity in businesses and facilitate the study of how various types and purposes of generosity affect a business's conditions and goals. Focusing on processes allows researchers to go beyond mere correlations and investigate how and why giving affects business outcomes. Therefore, a more conceptual and theoretical research framework can help clarify, structure, and deepen the study of generosity in the corporate world. A robust theoretical framework can help overcome many of the present constraints in generosity research by providing a unified definition of generosity, revealing its underlying mechanisms, and framing it as a strategic resource.

The remainder of this study is organized as follows. First, we explain the conceptualization of generosity in the literature and its forms. Next, we present GEF and its theoretical and practical implications. This study concludes with an agenda for future research.

2 Explaining generosity: conceptualization and operationalization

According to Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* (1122a-1122b), generosity was considered one of the three fundamental virtues of humanity, alongside courage and temperance (Beck, 2012) (Table 1). Aristotle posited that those who exhibit generosity do not engage in indiscriminate giving but instead direct their acts toward appropriate recipients, in suitable quantities, at opportune moments, with a sense of gratification, and without consideration for personal gain. In addition to this early philosophical approach, the two prominent disciplines dominating the field are sociology/social psychology and economics/management.

Generosity may be seen as a social virtue due to its capacity to serve as a tangible manifestation of interdependence among individuals, both as a means of demonstrating care toward others and as a means of reinforcing one's recognition of the reliance that human beings have on one another (Beck, 2012). Wilcox and Dew (2016) saw generosity as the act of purposefully giving to others in a manner that is beyond the bare minimum required to meet their basic needs. Generosity is widely recognized as a virtue that involves performing acts of kindness, care, and selfless love. It is driven

Table 1 The definitions of generosity by discipline and level of analysis

Author(s) (year)	Definition of Generosity	Discipline	Level
Aristotle (<i>Ethika Nicomachia</i> , 1122a-1122b)	One of the three human social virtues is expressed as giving people in real need the right amount, at the right time, with pleasure, and without regard for one's self-interest.	Philosophy	Micro level
Miller (2018); Smith and Davidson (2014)	Pure concern for others and genuine intentions to help and contribute, embrace, and encourage others	Social Psychology	Micro level
Sharp and Randhawa (2014); Kandul (2016).	Pure altruism	Social Psychology	Micro level
Wilcox and Dew (2016)	Meaningful giving to others, which goes at least above the minimum level of the other's needs,	Social Psychology	Micro level
Notre Dame's Center, Science of Generosity	The disposition and practice of freely giving of one's financial resources, time, and talents	Sociology	Micro level
Wilson (2012)	Represents three giving behaviors: helping a stranger, donating money for charity, and volunteering time	Sociology	Micro level
Jones et al., (2018); De-Bruin (2013)	How does the business treat others?; reflecting its obligation towards its employees, customers, and the community.	Marketing/Economics	Meso level
Hichri and Ltifi (2021)	Meaningful work; Social responsibility to the community (i.e., Corporate Social Responsibility)	Marketing/Economics	Meso level
Alam et al. (2023); Zoogah and Zoogah (2020)	Openness to yielding resources beyond what is required for an exchange. A gift is a reciprocal expectation between the giver and the receiver to contribute to one another	Economics	Meso level
Images (2014); Larivière et al., (2016);	'Having a heart' implies being sympathetic; customers may give and act generously with their hearts, not their heads.	Marketing/Economics	Meso level
Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007)	Business generosity is defined as labeling, recognition, and prestige given to the donor to influence the donation amount.	Non-profit marketing	Meso level
MacKenzie et al. (2019)	Philanthropic enterprises link donations with actual needs in ways that advance the purposes of donors—focusing on enhancing social responsibility and welfare in society.	Sociology	Macro level
Duclos and Barasch (2014)	Helping others; Contribute to their happiness	Sociology	Macro level
Nelson and Fritzell (2014)	Welfare generosity is a set of policies and plans aimed at social protection and enhancing residents' safety.	Sociology	Macro level

by genuine altruistic concern for others, without expecting anything in return, such as reciprocal favors, enhanced reputation, or personal benefits (Tsvetkova & Macy, 2014).

Kindness has recognized advantages and beneficial effects on the well-being, interpersonal connections, and general happiness of the individual demonstrating kindness and its recipient (Hui et al., 2020). It is noteworthy that although researchers may not address generosity explicitly, scholarly investigations frequently explore the notions of altruism, prosocial behavior, cooperation, and acts of kindness. These inquiries aim to elucidate the fundamental mechanisms, contextual factors, and motivational aspects that underlie these behaviors (Datu et al., 2022).

Many terms are used to express generosity. Prosocial behaviors—deeds that help others, often at one's own expense—are critical for our society. Terms used interchangeably to express generosity are “giving,” “donation(s),” “altruism,” “organizational citizenship behavior,” “volunteering,” “prosocial behavior,” and “philanthropy” (Collett & Morrissey, 2007; Wilson, 2012). A common presumption is that human generosity is a social behavior that benefits others, the community, or society.

Generosity and altruism both involve philanthropy and charity but with different underlying motivations and approaches (Collett & Morrissey, 2007). Philanthropy is the act of donating to a cause or personal relationships with beneficiaries based on emotional connections. Whereas both actions seek to do good, altruism emphasizes technical efficiency and global influence, whereas philanthropy is more emotionally driven and community-oriented (Kalulu, 2022). According to the Charity Aid Foundation (CAF) (2021), generosity behaviors include helping a stranger or someone not knowing who needs help, donating money to charity, and volunteering time to an organization. In a worldwide sample of 1.6 million people, CAF (2021) found that 55% of those surveyed helped a stranger, 31% donated money, and 19% volunteered during 2019–2020. Thus, generosity has been operationalized as an umbrella of monetary or non-monetary giving (e.g., money, service, effort, time, blood, organs, and in-kind).

As presented in Table 1, generosity has been the subject of substantial research in economics and management, where it is often defined as the sharing of resources or making cooperative decisions (Van Lange et al., 2002). When examined from an economic and managerial perspective, generosity is contingent upon adherence to certain principles or social norms of reciprocity. These norms dictate how an individual engages in acts of generosity in response to another individual's earlier actions, eliciting a sense of responsibility to reciprocate generously (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2010). Within the context of marketing and business, generosity is commonly viewed through the lens of ethical virtues in business. This conceptualization is often associated with the concept of corporate social responsibility (CSR; Mansouri et al., 2024), which, in turn, has been linked to the promotion of meaningful work and the cultivation of customer loyalty and intention to engage in charitable giving (Hichri & Ltifi, 2021).

To summarize, generosity has occupied an explicative role in the domains of charitable giving and donation behavior (Duclos & Barasch, 2014), volunteering, and corporate giving (Marquis & Lee, 2013). Generosity, as addressed in prosocial behavior theories, refers to an altruistic activity that seeks to benefit others (Dovidio et al., 2006). Thus, generosity may be operationalized as the voluntary act of giving resources to others, such as time, money, or effort, to improve their well-being without expecting reciprocal benefit or direct personal gain. The principle of not expecting reciprocity and personal benefit is critical in distinguishing generosity from acts motivated by self-interest or strategic goals (Darley & Batson, 1973).

To quantify generosity in an empirical study, behavioral measures need to be determined, such as the number of resources donated, frequency of helpful acts, or duration of time spent in altruistic activities (Penner et al., 2005). Similar considerations apply to self-reported measures, such as scales assessing the individual's attitudes toward helping others, self-reported intentions to engage in prosocial actions, or per-

ceptions of the benefits of helping (Rushton et al., 1981). Motivation-based assessments can be used to operationalize the psychological components of generosity, differentiating between altruistic motivations, which are solely concerned with the well-being of others, and egoistic motivations, which may include personal benefits such as social approval (Finkelstein et al., 2009). In this view, a complete measure of generosity should take into account both the visible manifestations of generous acts and the underlying altruistic impulses that motivate them.

3 Generosity as a marketing strategy

Marketers must continually seek ways to connect with customers, develop new products and services, create relevant offers to stimulate sales, and collect customer feedback and meaningful data. Generosity is essential for addressing the ongoing needs of the less fortunate, developing new solutions to solve growing problems, creating meaningful ways to engage others in helping, and continually analyzing the situation to ensure that efforts are being applied effectively (Fergusonvalues, 2012). Generosity in marketing (e.g., offering free content, samples, money-back guarantees, donations, or participation in cause-related marketing) can help establish customer trust and loyalty (Jeng et al., 2014; Rapert et al., 2021). These measures signal that the brand cares about customers' needs beyond sales. Moreover, adopting a generous, *other-centric* approach can help a brand stand out from competitors and be perceived as more authentic and trustworthy (Rapert et al., 2021), resulting in increased patronage intentions (Jeng et al., 2014). Acts of generosity by a brand can attract media attention and inspire customers to become brand advocates, leading to valuable word-of-mouth marketing. A recent study (Engage for Good, 2023) reported that 76% of Americans believe that supporting firms that address social and environmental concerns makes them feel like they are doing their part, and 86% say that they are more likely to buy from purpose-driven businesses. For example, an outstanding case of generosity in marketing is TOMS pioneering the One for One model, where, for every pair of shoes purchased, the company donates shoes to a child in need. This purpose-driven marketing approach has resonated with socially conscious consumers, helping TOMS grow into a billion-dollar brand. Another case of generosity is the Gardens of the Sun, a jewelry maker who plants a tree for every piece sold, thus engaging in environmental causes (Pressley et al., 2024). Connecting purchases to charitable causes fosters goodwill and loyalty among customers who support ethical brands. Company generosity can improve customer relationships by bringing "magic and enchantment" back to marketing (Amar, 2015).

Furthermore, when a brand demonstrates generosity toward its employees and community, it can boost employee satisfaction and retention, further strengthening the brand. According to the Deloitte Volunteer Survey (2024), almost nine out of 10 working Americans (91%) say that firms that offer volunteer activities have a better overall working environment than those that do not. Almost all (95%) of the respondents stated that it is vital to them to have a positive effect in their communities, and the best method for their firm to support their capacity to do so is by establishing in-person interactions with community groups (52%). In summary, generosity can

be a powerful marketing strategy that can help brands build stronger customer relationships, differentiate themselves, and generate positive publicity. However, these benefits necessitate a sincere, long-term commitment to delivering value rather than relying on short-term promotional tactics.

4 The generosity ecosystem framework (GEF)

Generosity can have a positive impact on everything, from minor issues to significant societal problems, affecting the entire social ecosystem at the micro, meso, and macro levels. Therefore, GEF zooms out generosity to include all actors/stakeholders, contexts, and interactions that create value for individuals, communities, and societies (Fig. 1). We proceed by presenting the role of generosity at each ecosystem level. We employed the actors-antecedents-decisions-outcomes (AADO) organizing framework (Tsiotsou & Boukis, 2022) to identify key actors, their interactions and their influences at each level of the ecosystem.

4.1 Generosity at the macro level

The macro level refers to broader societal structures and cultural norms that shape attitudes toward generosity. This includes governmental policies, economic conditions, and societal values that either encourage or inhibit charitable behavior. According to the CAF World Giving Index (2021), each country is ranked on three giving behaviors: helping a stranger, donating money for charity, and volunteering time (Table 2). The U.S. ranked first in monetary donations, followed by the United Kingdom and Ireland. Regarding helping a stranger, Liberia was ranked first, followed by Sierra Leone and the U.S. (Wiepking, 2021). Thus, some societies have a more generous character than others, while more than a third of the world's population engages in acts of generosity.

Duclos and Barasch (2014) found that generosity is driven by belief systems that differ between individualistic and collectivistic nations. In collectivistic cultures, helping others is believed to contribute to givers' and receivers' happiness,

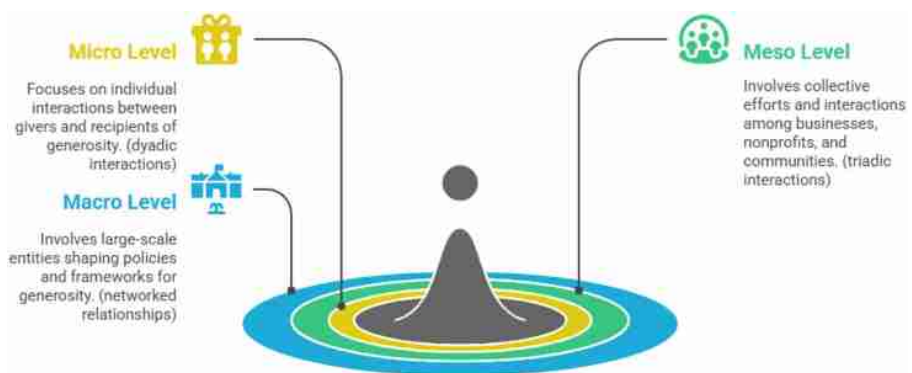


Fig. 1 The generosity ecosystem, main actors, and interaction types

Table 2 Actors, antecedents, decisions, and outcomes of generosity at the macro level

MACRO LEVEL

Networked relationships (Governments, Policy Makers, Unions, Institutions)

References:	Actors:	Antecedents	Decisions (generosity displays)	Outcomes
CAF World Giving Index (2021); Liu and Hao (2017) Choi and Seo (2017) Duclos and Barasch (2014); Miller et al. (2014)	Country's citizens	Social norms (collectivistic or individualistic) Belief system. Hidden agenda in individualistic cultures: high expectation for return	Helping a stranger, Donating money for charity Investing volunteering time.	Enhancing personal happiness of the giver; Inclination to act generously
Gschwind (2021) Finamor and Scott (2021) Biegert et al. (2022)	Policy makers. Governmental public agencies	Unemployment benefit provision Greater state welfare generosity Generosity welfare Societal belief system and social norms	Provincial welfare generosity: Policies & plans aimed at social protection. Medical care & preventive care Social services Education.	Greater residents' sense of safety; Enhance well-being & healthier lives Reduce mortality level
Brunt and Jensen (2013)	Physicians	Geographic payment distortions; Medicaid payment rates Self-construal	Accepting new Medicare patients; Giving medical charities	Enhance equality in health treatment & patients' wellbeing
Hichri and Ltifi (2021) Chen & Yang (2023)	Governmental regulators, Investors Firms/ Businesses	World establishing the criteria & standards for business sustainability (ESG). Demand for corporate social responsibility	Act responsibly towards employees, customers & suppliers	Boost firm value Lower the cost of equity capital Increase financial profits Enhance customers & employees' wellbeing

thus increasing their inclination to act generously. However, cultures with communal norms expect less reciprocity than individualistic cultures (Miller et al., 2014). Cultural norms in exchange relationships, as in individualistic societies, are built on expectations of reciprocity in return for a received gift. Thus, individualistic cultures have different motives for acting generously and have high expectations for return (Choi & Seo, 2017). Welfare generosity (e.g., broad eligibility for coverage and duration of benefits and services) reflects generosity at the country level (Gschwind, 2021). Citizens perceive welfare generosity as a set of policies and plans for social protection. Welfare generosity provides citizens with a greater sense of safety and protection against challenging situations, thus enhancing their well-being and assisting them in living healthier and longer lives (Biegert et al., 2022; Nelson & Fritzell, 2014). Thus, generosity at the macro level reflects the allocation of a country's resources (e.g., money, infrastructure, and personnel) to social services, healthcare (medical care and preventive care), and education.

However, the macro level does not operate in isolation but is interrelated to the meso and micro levels via policies and cultural norms. Specifically, government incentives in the form of tax exemptions for charitable donations can enhance overall

giving rates. For example, tax deductions for charitable contributions can motivate actors at the meso level (e.g., businesses and foundations) and micro level (e.g., individuals giving more generously). In the United States, corporations can deduct charitable contributions of up to 10% of their taxable income. This deduction reduces the effective cost of giving, making it more attractive for businesses to donate. According to Giving USA (2024), charitable giving by individuals has reached \$374.4 billion, \$103.3 billion by foundations and \$36.55 billion by corporations in 2023. In South Africa, the percentage of taxpayers making donations rose from 0.55% in 2011 to 0.90% in 2021, reflecting the influence of tax incentives on donor behavior (Chingwere et al., 2024). Moreover, societies that value altruism and community support tend to foster environments in which generosity thrives at both the micro and meso levels. For instance, cultures with strong traditions of communal support often see higher rates of volunteerism and charitable giving (Allen, 2018).

4.2 Generosity at the meso level

The meso level encompasses organizations and communities that facilitate collective acts of generosity (Table 3). This includes nonprofits, foundations, businesses, community groups, and social networks that organize charitable events or campaigns. At this level, the sharing of resources and information among organizations can enhance overall generosity within a community. Foundations serve as essential sponsors of charities by providing financial support, raising awareness, advocating for policy changes, fostering innovation, and facilitating collaboration among nonprofits. Their multifaceted role not only enhances the capacity of individual organizations but also contributes to broader societal change by effectively addressing pressing social issues (Gari, 2024). For example, the Human Rights Campaign Foundation advocates for LGBTQ+ rights and influences policies that promote equality and fairness across various sectors. Through strategic investments and partnerships, these foundations help create sustainable solutions that benefit communities worldwide. For example, the Rockefeller Foundation partners with various organizations to address global challenges such as climate change, pooling resources and expertise to drive collective action.

Corporate generosity is fostered through formal and informal organizational practices, skills, and norms and is shared and absorbed among managers, employees, and customers (Table 3). Specifically, generosity develops through repeated positive reactions to employee or customer problems, which build high-quality relationships (de Bruin, 2013). This can occur when the organization remains open to differences and shows a deep interest in the well-being and diverse needs of others, cultivating qualities such as courage, self-discipline, and justice. Trust is a key component of this openness, an important predictor of generosity behaviors through cooperative behavior; trust “creates an expectation that others will act on behalf of the common good” (Neilson & Paxton, 2010, p. 9). Harrison and Wicks (2019) showed that stakeholders’ generosity is part of their relational ethical principles in the business. Instrumental stakeholder theory suggests that corporations add more value and growth when their stakeholder relationships are governed generously as an ethical virtue (Jones et al., 2018). Thus, business generosity is often discussed in terms of ethics and respectful

Table 3 Actors, antecedents, decisions, and outcomes of generosity at the meso level

MESO LEVEL

Triadic relationships (Businesses, Nonprofits, Communities)

References:	Actors:	Antecedents	Decisions (generosity displays)	Outcomes
Harrison and-Wicks (2019); Jones et al. (2018)	Stakeholders	Relational ethical principals	Create generous relationship; Visible positive actions Emphasize fairness, integrity, love & humbleness	Add value and growth; employees inspire to engage in generous actions
MacKenzie et al.,n 2019; Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007); Tsotsou (2004) Dwidienawati and Abdinagoro (2018)	Stakeholders Fundraisers	Hidden agenda of exchange relationships	Donors high trust, & commitment; Giving generous donations by donors	Raising more corporate money; Lessen costs; Economics benefits
Sen et al. (2016)	Business donations/ Stakeholders	Suspicious with regard to business honesty/hidden motives Doubt corporate social responsibility	Act negatively towards the business	Damaging customer generosity
Neilson and Paxton (2010); de Bruin, 2013; Imas (2014); Choi and Seo (2017); Larivière et al. (2016)	Managers & Employees	Cultivates caring thoughtful relationship with all partners; Expectation that others will act on behalf of the common good.	Customers perceive business core values as align with their own personal values Customers act generously;	Increases trust and loyalty; Help the business to recruit & retain qualify employees; Keep high performance; Enhances employees' energy.
Wu et al., 2021; Anand and Walsh, (2016);	Managers & Employees	Environmental misconduct (e.g., pollution; Justice & integrity; Knowledge sharing; Openness to diversity of others' needs. Deep interest in the wellbeing of others, Self-discipline; Religiosity	Proactive approach; Preserve green image; Informal ethical practices in the business; Repeated patterns of positive reactions to employees. Conduct visible positive actions; Enhance knowledge sharing; Being sympathetic & generous.	Enhance a firm's competitive advantage & business productivity Business reputational & high status benefits Increase revenue Increase customer's positive outcomes: loyalty, trust; positive emotions; ethical respectful behavior & Cultivating courage & self-discipline

Table 3 (continued)

MESO LEVEL				
Triadic relationships (Businesses, Nonprofits, Communities)				
References:	Actors:	Antecedents	Decisions (generosity displays)	Outcomes
Keenan et al. (2022) Arief et al.(2020);	Customers	A combination of business objectives and intentions of giving and helping others	Participating in CRM programs Pro social behavior	Enhance positive emotions & positive behavioral intentions; Customers' view purchasing as a prosocial behavior
Lynn and Starbuck (2015)	Customers	Social norms Reciprocal generosity effect (customer perceived business generosity)	Perceiving suitable giving level Act generously Customer sense of duty	Enhance tip size Participate in the CRM program
Bluvstein Netter and Raghubir (2021); Jung et al. (2014). Aronson et al. (2015); Bernritter et al. (2017)	Customers	Impression management motivations, Others exhibit high level of giving Receiving persuasive messages	Generous tipping & donation behavior Customer's high involvement	Increased tip size Increased positive emotions Increased tipping behavior
Small & Cyder (2016)	Customers	Customer high involvement	Suitable giving level for the good of others or of society. Customer's altruism	Increased purchase behavior
Saccardo et al., (2021); Small and Cryder (2016); Zhang et al.(2021)	Customers	Customer elective pricing, Extrinsic rewards and Reputational benefits, Problematic donations Price promotions	Awareness of social considerations, Purchasing pleasure Knowing that I am a good person; Aim to make a tangible impact on someone; Altruist donation	Increase payments and donations, Increased generosity & giving Consumers' donation behavior
Liu and Hao (2017)	Customers	Customer socio economic status High status expect reciprocity for generosity Low status customers give out of gratitude	Customer acting generously	
Mellstrom & Johannesson (2008)	Customers	'Crowding out' phenomena extrinsic rewards for generosity damage intrinsic motivation	Donation meaning shifting from an act of kindness to a behavior conducted in return for extrinsic rewards such as payment	Decrease the value of prosocial behavior; Damaging customer generosity

and generous relationships between all stakeholders. Business philanthropy and ethics are described as visible positive actions characterized by generosity, fairness, and integrity, which inspire employees to engage in generous actions (de Bruin, 2013; Jones et al., 2018). Accordingly, generosity is a central element of quality relation-

ships with all business parties, including customers who experience positive relationships with the business.

Nevertheless, the nonprofit marketing perspective (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007; Tsiotsou, 2004) assumes exchange relationships in generous acts. Therefore, by enhancing contributors' pleasure, trust, and commitment, fundraisers have the potential to generate higher levels of financial contributions. Scholars have explored the antecedents of philanthropic behaviors in companies by examining the potential reputational advantages donors may receive. These investigations include an analysis of the business's standing and influence within the market (MacKenzie et al., 2019). Business entities may exhibit acts of generosity but with an ulterior motive to obtain certain benefits, such as acknowledgment and client loyalty (Choi & Seo, 2017).

4.2.1 The effect of business generosity on employees and customers

Dwidienawati and Abdinagoro (2018) argued that businesses that act generously may accrue potential economic benefits. For instance, cause-related marketing (CRM) is an effective marketing tool that links businesses in helping behaviors and enables customers to view purchasing as prosocial behavior. CRM presents a combination of business objectives, purposes, and acts of giving. Business generosity can influence customers' positive emotions and intentions, which are critical to customer loyalty (Choi & Seo, 2017).

Successful businesses can be more generous with their employees, customers, and communities because they have more to share. However, generosity often precedes achievement and success and even plays a crucial role in helping businesses thrive. By enhancing the human energy needed to serve customers and foster trust, generosity helps companies compete effectively. Companies such as Costco, Luxottica, Genesco, Zane's Cycles, and Lowe's illustrate that generosity is a key driver of success rather than merely its by product (Berry, 2007).

A generous attitude inside the organization can contribute to the business. For instance, knowledge sharing (Anand & Walsh, 2016) falls under the umbrella of business generosity, which has been shown to enhance a firm's competitive advantage (Argote & Ingram, 2000). By sharing knowledge, companies can ensure that valuable information remains in the business even after employees leave.

Business generosity is a crucial factor in cultivating a positive overall organizational mood, creating trust and value in terms of winning customers' and employees' hearts, which, in turn, helps the business recruit and retain qualified employees and maintain high performance (de Bruin, 2013). Corporate generosity cultivates caring and thoughtful relationships with all partners; it emphasizes that the business "has a heart," knowing that this quality is acknowledged by customers and communities. Consequently, 'having a heart' implies sympathy. Thus, customers may give and act generously with their hearts rather than their heads (Imas, 2014).

Larivière et al. (2016) posited that a business's generosity enhances customer positive outcomes, such as trust, satisfaction, loyalty, and cooperation. Supporting the reciprocal generosity effect, Berry (2007) showed that customers recognize high corporate generosity, prompting them to be more emotionally connected to the business and, in turn, more generous. Customers become emotionally connected to the

business and perceive its core values as aligning with theirs. However, research is lacking on how business generosity affects customers' loyalty or intention to continue the relationship with the business (Choi & Seo, 2017).

Customers may not always react positively to business donations (Small & Cryder, 2016). For instance, when customers have doubts about corporate social responsibility and are suspicious of business dishonesty and hidden motives for its benefit, they may act negatively toward the business (Sen et al., 2016).

4.2.2 Customers' generosity toward the business

Lynn and Starbuck (2015) found that customers' generosity, as expressed in their tip size, is influenced by the sense of duty that the customer feels toward the employees and the business. When customers are generous and tip more, their generosity can bring about positive emotions (Aronson et al., 2016). Another benefit to the organization is that customers' positive emotions enhance their positive behavioral intention to participate in CRM programs (Arief et al., 2020). Recently, Zhang et al. (2021) demonstrated that the positive effect of price promotions on consumers' donation behavior was weakened when consumers absorbed the total money they spent rather than the amount they saved due to price promotion. Customers' social norms can explain this phenomenon, as well as potent indications of a suitable giving level. When consumers assume that others exhibit a high level of giving, they will also give more (Jung et al., 2014).

Bernritter et al. (2017) posited that customers' level of involvement is associated positively with their generosity. Consumer generosity is induced by extrinsic rewards, reputational benefits, and a sense of pleasure from knowing that 'I am a good person' (Small & Cryder, 2016). Indeed, Choi and Seo (2017) argued that high-status customers expect business reciprocity for their generosity, whereas low-status customers give out of gratitude.

Consumers tend to be more generous when giving is difficult or even physically uncomfortable, such as when donating blood. This inclination can be attributed to the altruism associated with challenging acts of giving. Conversely, the phenomenon of 'crowding out' describes the opposite situation, where a customer's motivation shifts from a genuine desire to help to behavior driven by extrinsic rewards, such as payment. This can be seen in examples like volunteering or donating blood (Silva Carlos & Rodrigues, 2024).

4.3 Generosity at the micro level

At the micro level, individual actions and behaviors represent the foundation of the generosity ecosystem. This includes personal acts of kindness, charitable donations, and volunteering. Acting from generosity involves having the 'asset of generosity,' reflecting that what is provided by the action is of value to the giver (Miller, 2018). When studying generosity at the individual level, we first examine what it means to act generously. Specifically, what makes a person generous? Is there any hidden agenda behind the individual's generous act? Studies reviewing individuals' motives for generosity are characterized by a lack of consistency (Table 4). Researchers have

Table 4 Actors, antecedents, decisions, and outcomes of generosity at the micro level

MICRO LEVEL

Dyadic relationships (Giver - Recipient of generosity)

References:	Actors:	Antecedents	Decisions	Outcomes
Rapert et al. (2021) Xu et al. (2020); Kandul (2016); Sharp & Randhawa, 2014; Smith and Davidson, (2014)	Individuals	Values; Having the asset of generosity; Pure concern to other's wellbeing Pursuing righteousness & fairness	Wish to encourage & contribute others Moral self-concept (impact on recipients' lives)	Increase charitable behaviors Being generous Show prosocial behavior
Jin et al. (2020) Miller (2018); Strauss et al. (2016)	Individuals	Compassion; Pure empathy; Pure altruism; Benevolence; Humanity; Self-construal;	Long lasting relationship with a group	Generosity in economic sharing behavior Being generous with close others
Wang & Bowen (2024); Proulx et al. (2023); Liu and Hao (2017); Kandul, 2016; Charles-sire et al. (2014); Sharp and Randhawa (2014); Duclos & Barasch, 2014; Declerck et al. (2013)	Individuals	Giver's intrinsic rewards (enjoy previous act: happiness; experience of mankind connection & human cooperation; Enjoys the fruits of his/her deeds: gratitude; pleasure; feeling pure morality; satisfaction in life; positive health outcomes; wellbeing)	Not aimed at achieving something in advance. No hidden agenda; Future generous intentions;	Continues giving more Positive circle of giving
MacKenzie et al., 2019; Smith and Davidson (2014); Tsiotsou, 2006;	Individuals	Reciprocal expectations to be intrinsically/ extrinsically rewarded: tangible extrinsic prizes (payment or gift) & intangible extrinsic rewards (decent reputation)	A definite agenda & hidden motivation behind the generous act; Generosity is not identical to altruism; donor interests;	Give and take Future intentions to act generously
Romano et al., 2021 Nielson, Padilla-walker, & Holmes (2017); Saslow et al. (2013); Tsiotsou (2006); Tsiotsou (2004)	Individuals	Demographics: <i>Age, Gender Education, income age & religiosity</i>	Older adults are more generous in relation to young and middle-aged people. Males are less generous than females	Generosity Donations Tips Online giving compliments

adopted numerous perspectives and terminologies to define generosity at the individual level.

Strauss et al. (2016) suggested compassion as an antecedent of generosity. Miller (2018) added benevolence in addition to compassion and empathy. Benevolence is defined in terms of trustworthiness and integrity (Pirson & Malhotra, 2011), behaving in others' best interests, and doing so in various contexts. Gillespie and Dietz (2009) refer to stakeholders' benevolence as a combination of self-assuredness and positive expectations of the organization's plans and actions. Self-construal, a person's relationship with a group with which an individual identifies, can also predict generosity.

Declerck et al. (2013) suggested that individuals find joy in giving due to the benefits of human cooperation rather than from ordinary extrinsic compensation. Indeed, the social-psychological viewpoint holds that although the positive outcomes of generosity can turn out to be emotionally rewarding, the original motives to act generously do not derive from the desire to achieve something. Thus, individuals may express generosity with no hidden agenda; they become generous based on pure empathy or altruism (Kandul, 2016; Sharp & Randhawa, 2014) and their humanity (Strauss et al., 2016). Aligning with this view, research has shown that individuals are generous because they are motivated by empathy and concern for others' well-being (Sharp & Randhawa, 2014). Positive experiences, such as happiness resulting from past generous acts, will follow future generous intentions and create a positive circle of giving (Duclos & Barasch, 2014).

Social psychologists argue that by acting generously, individuals gain positive feelings such as gratitude, pleasure, a warm feeling of connection with humankind (Declerck et al., 2013; Kandul, 2016; Liu & Hao, 2017; Sharp & Randhawa, 2014), and pure morality (Charles-Sire et al., 2014). However, as noted, these intrinsic positive feelings do not reflect the hidden motives or agendas behind individuals' generous acts.

In contrast to the social-psychological perspective, the economics marketing perspective highlights the hidden agendas of the giver; these encompass intrinsic rewards as the incentive for the act of giving, especially the reciprocal expectations between the giver and the receiver (MacKenzie et al., 2019; Codrea, 2014; Tsiotsou, 2004, 2006). Thus, generosity has value to the receiver and is beneficial to the giver (Smith & Davidson, 2014). When generosity is defined as a gift (Codrea, 2014), individuals may be extrinsically motivated to act generously and expect tangible rewards, such as payment or valuable gifts. Additionally, they may anticipate intangible rewards such as a decent reputation. This approach helps explain why individuals occasionally expect reciprocity when giving a gift (Codrea, 2014).

5 Discussion

The proposed framework combines new and existing knowledge to advance our understanding of generosity while revealing significant disparities in how researchers view generosity in the social and economic sciences. Generosity has been examined in several forms (e.g., granting money, time, effort, and skills) for many years. However, such studies have often emanated from diverse and sometimes unrelated fields (psychology, political science, sociology, and nonprofit marketing), often relating to numerous concepts such as charity, volunteering, and altruism (Sen et al., 2016; Tsiotsou, 2004; Wiepking, 2021). Thus, the proposed GEF framework provides valuable theoretical and practical implications.

5.1 Theoretical implications

The proposed framework, GEF, advances our understanding and knowledge of generosity by identifying disparities and common understandings across disciplines,

and extending its conceptualization and operationalization. Generosity has yet to be universally defined and conceptualized, with expectations of reciprocity being the critical point of disagreement. Management/marketing views a reciprocal relationship in generosity (Larivière et al., 2016; Tsiotsou, 2004), whereas social psychology takes an altruistic perspective in defining the concept (Miller, 2018). Consequently, the most prominent discussion among scholars is their respective positions on the presence of a hidden agenda behind generosity. These two perspectives, however, concur that both the givers and the recipients benefit from generosity. Based on the ecosystem perspective in the proposed framework, we conceptualize *generosity* as a multifaceted social virtue and a type of prosocial behavior that aims to enhance the well-being of others, the community, and the society by providing resources freely and abundantly, without expecting anything in return. Thus, it is characterized by a mindset of kindness and a desire to enhance the social well-being, often driven by a sense of moral obligation or personal fulfillment. Generosity encompasses acts of informal and formal giving of resources. Giving is not limited to material resources, such as money or possessions (e.g., food and clothing), but also intangible resources, like time (e.g., volunteering to support others), skills/effort (e.g., sharing expertise such as environmental sustainability literacy to benefit others), and emotional support (e.g., offering comfort and encouragement). Consequently, our operationalization of generosity extends to actions that contribute to the public good in a broader context, such as engaging in political activism, donating blood and organs, promoting environmental sustainability, providing informal assistance, and exhibiting relational generosity (Silva Carlos & Rodrigues, 2024; Wilson, 2012). According to GEF, generosity should be operationalized based on the ecosystem's level of analysis. This clears up some of the confusion and discrepancies in the literature in the past.

The ecosystem perspective embraced by GEF enhances the understanding of generosity in social science and marketing by emphasizing interconnectedness, collaboration, and mutual benefit of the actors involved. From this point of view, the focus is moved from the actions of a single person or company to a larger system of actors and forces that are co-evolving, encouraging long-term value co-creation. Furthermore, the ecosystem approach helps clarify the inconsistencies and misinterpretations in the generosity literature. Thus, the ecosystem perspective reframes generosity as a strategic tool rather than a purely altruistic act. In social science, it underscores the systemic drivers of prosocial behavior, whereas in marketing, it highlights how generosity fosters collaboration, trust, and sustainable competitive advantage within dynamic ecosystems. The proposed framework encourages organizations to think beyond transactional relationships toward creating shared value for all stakeholders and a flourishing society.

At the macro level, generosity refers to the resources invested in social programs developed by governments and supported by other institutions, such as political and religious institutions and philanthropic organizations (Gschwind, 2021; Wiepking, 2021). Generosity plays a significant role in shaping societal structures, economic policies, and social cohesion. Generosity at the macro level, such as through welfare systems or large-scale philanthropy, can enhance social cohesion by fostering a sense of shared responsibility and community. Welfare generosity, a form of macro-level generosity, can have significant economic effects. It can influence employment

rates by providing financial support to vulnerable populations, thus impacting overall economic stability. Thus, in turn, generosity strengthens trust among citizens and between citizens and institutions.

At the meso level, GEF signifies that generosity is part of the business ethical culture and not an isolated act. At this level of analysis, generosity refers to business, foundations, and community generosity to individuals, communities, and non-profit organizations (Keenan et al., 2022; Zhang et al., 2021). Generosity is shaped by the organization's formal and informal practices, skills, and norms. A culture of generosity is fostered by an organization offering positive responses to employees' and customers' problems, building high-quality relationships, promoting openness to diversity, and showing genuine interest in the well-being of others. Trust is crucial in promoting generous behaviors and expecting others to act toward the common good (Pirson & Malhotra, 2011). Stakeholder generosity is a component of ethical business practice. Thus, businesses can add value and growth by managing stakeholder relationships with generosity as an ethical virtue (Harrison & Wicks, 2019). Generosity within organizations, such as knowledge sharing, can enhance a firm's competitive advantage and cultivate a positive overall mood, trust, and value, helping businesses recruit and retain qualified employees (Anand & Walsh, 2016; Wu et al., 2021). Expressions of generosity also create caring and thoughtful relationships between partners and customers. Notably, however, not all consumers respond favorably to company contributions, particularly if they have questions about CSR or suspect ulterior agendas. Indeed, hidden intentions may underlie the deeds of giving, and corporations may behave generously in anticipation of reputational advantages (Yoon et al., 2006).

Furthermore, GEF signifies that generosity is not a one way act (from businesses or employees to consumers) but a two-way act (from employees to consumers and from consumers to employees). Several variables impact consumers' generosity and tipping habits toward employees. Positive feelings, astonishment, and a sense of obligation to employees and the organization may contribute to bigger tips (Bluvstein & Raghubir, 2021). Consumer generosity is also influenced by social norms and their perceptions of others' donating levels (Rapert et al., 2021; Xu et al., 2020). Customers' degree of engagement and anticipation of reciprocity or thankfulness may all impact their generosity. Furthermore, because of the compassion connected with such activities, consumers may be more generous when donating is unpleasant or physically uncomfortable. However, when extrinsic benefits transform the meaning of generosity from an act of kindness to a behavior performed to obtain remuneration or other rewards, the phenomenon of "crowding out" may occur (Mellström & Johannesson, 2008).

At the micro level, GEF provides an understanding of the generosity's complexities and sheds light on its multifaceted nature by combining its underlying causes and motivations. At this level, generosity involves dyadic interactions between individuals (e.g., employees with customers) (Jin et al., 2020; Rapert et al., 2021; Tsiotsou, 2006). Personality traits, such as humility and agreeableness, are positively associated with heightened levels of generosity, whereas prosocial conduct might be seen as an inherent characteristic of an individual's personality. Engaging in charity giving may be influenced by an individual's ideals, morals, and sense of identity (Kan-

dul, 2016; Xu et al., 2020). Several intrapersonal characteristics, such as empathy, compassion, fairness standards, and other emotions, may influence generosity (Jin et al., 2020; Miller, 2018). Furthermore, gender and religion may impact generosity, although various studies' findings have occasionally produced contradictory or complex outcomes (Romano et al., 2021; Tsiotsou, 2006). Socioeconomic status and individual characteristics influence generosity, with poorer and wealthier individuals being more generous than middle class individuals (Liu & Hao, 2017). Personal characteristics can also influence generosity decisions. Geographical and governmental factors and parenting practices can influence generosity (Gschwind, 2021). Strong social networks may influence generosity. People with more friends, for example, have been found to be more likely to volunteer, give more to charity, and donate blood (Silva Carlos & Rodrigues, 2024). Furthermore, generosity is infectious; it may spread via social networks and organizations (Tsvetkova & Macy, 2014).

Furthermore, GEM illustrates the transformative value of generosity not only for the recipients but also for donors. Studies on generosity have underscored the importance of exploring possible advantages to donors through acts of giving. The provision of social support, whether in the form of temporary, intangible, financial, or material resources, has been associated with enhanced overall well-being and a reduced likelihood of mortality. Strong associations have been reported between generosity and several positive psychological outcomes, including improved mental well-being, enhanced quality of life, increased vitality, and heightened self-esteem. Individuals have been shown to experience more happiness when they allocate their financial resources to others rather than themselves. This positive emotional experience motivates individuals to exhibit increased generosity in subsequent interactions. Biegert et al. (2022) argued that even minor acts of benevolence (e.g., retrieving an item that an individual has inadvertently dropped) can elicit happiness.

5.2 Practical implications

The interplay between the micro, meso, and macro levels creates a dynamic ecosystem where generosity is cultivated. Individual actions inspire community engagement, whereas organizational collaborations amplify these efforts within a supportive societal framework. Understanding these interrelations is vital for developing effective strategies to promote generosity at all levels. Societies can enhance overall well-being and social cohesion by fostering an environment in which generosity is valued and encouraged at every level.

GEF could benefit practitioners and policymakers in many ways. Knowledge about public funding assists the public sector in making decisions about donations. The *crowding out* of individual and institutional contributions may successfully modify contributors' ideas of what is required at a specific organization. For example, research indicates that a cutback in government assistance, such as reduced grants from the National Endowment for the Arts (NEA), typically leads to increased private contributions. For example, private philanthropic donations to arts organizations increased by 60 cents for each dollar reduction in NEA funding during the budget cuts of the mid-1990s in the US (Dokko, 2007). This indicates that private contrib-

utors may modify their contributions in response to the extent of available public financing. Thus, information on public funding may aid in guiding decision-making processes in both businesses and governments.

Businesses can effectively incorporate generosity initiatives into their CSR programs using various strategies such as matching gift programs, volunteer grants, annual giving campaigns, and community grants that not only support charitable causes but also engage employees and enhance the company's reputation. For example, in matching gift programs, companies can implement matching gift initiatives where they match employee donations to nonprofit organizations. This encourages employees to contribute to causes they care about, effectively doubling the impact of their donations. Furthermore, businesses can offer volunteer grant programs that provide financial contributions to nonprofits based on the number of hours employees volunteer. This incentivizes employees to engage in community service while also supporting the organizations they serve. Furthermore, companies can establish grant programs that allow nonprofits to apply for funding for specific projects or needs, thereby directly supporting community initiatives and fostering partnerships with local organizations.

Given the various forms generosity takes, managers of non-profit organizations are advised not to be limited to monetary giving campaigns but to try to incorporate other forms of giving (e.g., time, skills, blood, and organs) depending on the level of readiness and availability of each giver. The proposed framework offers a clearer understanding of why individuals and businesses are generous, as well as the circumstances that affect their generosity. Fundraisers and marketing managers need to understand the psychological, social, cultural, and environmental factors that influence generosity when designing campaigns to elicit the generosity of specific demographics.

Fundraisers and marketing managers typically strive to build strong bonds between donors and recipients in their programs. It would be valuable for these workers to understand that cultures of generosity emerge from a reliable community of givers comprising marriages, families, and friends, where members are encouraged to regularly reflect on the good that has been done and are provided with opportunities to influence one another. Thus, boosting prosocial campaigns on social media can promote the development of social networks to benefit from the contagious effects of generosity. Fundraisers can create engaging posts on social media by highlighting personal stories related to the cause to foster emotional connections and encourage sharing among followers. Moreover, they can host live-streaming events on social media platforms. For example, St. Jude Children's Research Hospital has successfully hosted live-streamed events featuring celebrities, where viewers could donate in real-time while enjoying entertainment and learning about the impact of their contributions. Furthermore, it established St. Jude PLAY LIVE, a charitable streaming event for content creators and gamers to generate funds to assist innovative pediatric cancer research and treatment at the hospital.

As noted, generosity is linked to numerous benefits to the givers (e.g., better health and quality of life, as well as increased well-being) and not only to the receivers. Consequently, businesses and nonprofit organizations should design their communication messages to stress these positive outcomes for the givers rather than solely

promoting the needs of the organization, community, or individual. As reciprocity, even in the form of positive feelings, is a critical trigger for generosity behavior, fundraising/marketing efforts could benefit from an enhanced understanding of the benefits (hidden or not) acquired by the givers.

6 Future research agenda

Considerable research has investigated generosity and its many manifestations. However, we have identified several research gaps while developing GEF. First, research consideration must be given to theoretical disparities in the sorts of resources (e.g., time, effort, and skills) that people share with others and their motives for doing so. Second, while extensive research has been devoted to the motivations of givers and the antecedents of generosity, there is a need for further exploration of the outcomes of generosity for givers and receivers, as the advantages of generosity have tended to be inferred rather than demonstrated. Although generosity is primarily about the receiver, there is minimal research on the consequences of generosity for the beneficiary at the macro (citizens), meso (e.g., communities and employees), and micro (individuals) levels. Most current research also overlooks the notion of the differential impact of generosity over the short and long term. Furthermore, most research findings derive from cultures with strong charitable giving inclinations, such as Anglo-Saxon cultures, with some exceptions (Wang & Boden, 2024). Thus, future research from other cultures and countries is needed to further understand the variations in generosity behavior.

Generosity under CSR has often drawn negative media and consumer attention (Mansouri et al., 2024) because of inconsistent business practices that question their genuineness. Thus, several questions need to be addressed. For example, does the lack of genuineness attributed to a generous act harm the generosity's potential to influence customers and donors? Does being generous externally (e.g., to individuals and communities) also require being generous internally (e.g., to employees)? Is there a canceling effect in the absence of a balance between external and internal generosity?

Further research is needed to fully understand how corporate generosity affects consumer loyalty, advocacy, and intention. More research is also needed on when and how employees are generous to a business and customers and how businesses can benefit from employees' generosity. Furthermore, we identified the need for studies specifying how customers can be generous toward businesses, both materially and otherwise. The role of gratitude as an outcome of generosity in the business-employee-customer relationship should also be investigated (Grover & Garima, 2024).

Based on GEF framework, we provide the following research questions to guide future endeavors:

1. How are altruistic and profit-motivated generosity actions expressed at the corporate level?

2. What are the dynamics of generosity becoming contagious among employees over time?
3. How do cultural norms and institutional frameworks mitigate the influence of commercial generosity on organizational performance and stakeholder perceptions?
4. What is the role of corporate generosity as an organizational culture in coping with crises?
5. What is the link between state or business generosity and individual or community dignity and agency?
6. How is generosity perceived by the recipient(s) of different demographics?
7. What are the unintended consequences of generosity (e.g., stigmatization)?
8. How does generosity create transformative value for the giver and the recipient at all levels of the generosity ecosystem?
9. What is the role of new technologies and artificial intelligence (AI) on generosity at all levels of the generosity ecosystem?

In summary, although there is a wealth of knowledge about people helping others, the existing literature lacks the integration and conceptual framework needed for theoretical progress. Although we argue for additional separation in terms of generosity forms and levels of analysis, such clarity is a constructive starting point for what can lead to a fuller and more holistic understanding of generosity.

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